

Comment in Response to the Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan

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Name: Michael Huang

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THE TRUMP DOCTRINE

“There are always [AI] risks, and it’s the first question I ask: how do you absolve yourself from mistake, etc., because it could be the rabbit that gets away. We’re not going to let that happen.”

- President Donald Trump¹

“I think the danger of AI is much greater than the danger of nuclear warheads by a lot and nobody would suggest that we allow anyone to build nuclear warheads if they want. That would be insane. And mark my words, AI is far more dangerous than nukes. Far. So why do we have no regulatory oversight? This is insane.”

- Elon Musk²

“Artificial intelligence is the future, not only for Russia, but for all humankind. It comes with colossal opportunities, but also threats that are difficult to predict. Whoever becomes the leader in this sphere will become the ruler of the world.”

- Russian President Vladimir Putin³

¹ Stephanie Lai, “For AI Watchers, Asked If He Had Any Concerns about Artificial Super Intelligence, Trump Said: ‘There Are Always Risks. And It’s the First Question I Ask, How Do You Absolve Yourself from Mistake, Because It Could Be the Rabbit That Gets Away, We’re Not Going to Let That Happen.’” <https://t.co/2bW1gsKMQL>, Tweet, *Twitter*, January 26, 2025, <https://x.com/stephanialai/status/1883336725700948036>.

² Catherine Clifford, “Elon Musk: ‘Mark My Words — A.I. Is Far More Dangerous than Nukes,’” *CNBC*, March 13, 2018, <https://www.cnbc.com/2018/03/13/elon-musk-at-sxsw-a-i-is-more-dangerous-than-nuclear-weapons.html>.

³ RT, “‘Whoever Leads in AI Will Rule the World’: Putin to Russian Children on Knowledge Day,” September 1, 2017, <https://www.rt.com/news/401731-ai-rule-world-putin/>.

Given the following assumptions:

- That the country that leads in AI will likely rule the world
- That America should continue to be the world's AI leader and leading superpower
- That foreign nations seek to overtake America's lead
- That AI will present both extreme opportunities and extreme risks

One can conclude:

- That limiting and containing AI development in foreign nations is as important to maintaining America's AI leadership as domestic AI development

There is a tradition in American foreign policy to describe a key goal or position as a presidential doctrine. The Trump administration should consider formally proclaiming a Trump Doctrine:

It is the policy of the United States of America to use every means at its disposal to achieve and maintain a monopoly in frontier artificial intelligence.

It would not only be an America First policy but an America Only policy. America was arguably at the peak of its power when it held a nuclear monopoly after World War II, from August of 1945 to August of 1949.⁴ America could experience the same dominance again with an AI monopoly. The potential for peace and prosperity in a new Pax Americana would be a lasting legacy of the Trump administration, a fulfilment of its Make America Great Again promise.

Enforcement of the Trump Doctrine

The American government currently has in place export controls on chips that are essential for AI development. However, widespread chip smuggling is undermining these export controls. One of the first tasks of enforcing the Trump Doctrine is to crack down on this illegal trade that undermines national security.⁵

The recent paper "Superintelligence Strategy" by Hendrycks, Schmidt and Wang⁶ introduced the concept of Mutual Assured AI Malfunction (MAIM), where preventative sabotage prevents rival

⁴ George H. Quester, *Nuclear Monopoly* (New Brunswick: Transaction Publishers, 2000).

⁵ Tim Fist and Erich Grunewald, "Preventing AI Chip Smuggling to China," Center for a New American Security, October 24, 2023, <https://www.cnas.org/publications/reports/preventing-ai-chip-smuggling-to-china>.

⁶ Dan Hendrycks, Eric Schmidt, and Alexandr Wang, "Superintelligence Strategy," 2025, <https://www.nationalsecurity.ai/>.

AI projects from taking off. The Trump administration should use elements from this strategy to enforce the Trump Doctrine:

- Espionage
- Covert or overt sabotage
- Covert or overt cyberattacks
- Kinetic strikes on datacenters

Diplomacy and the Trump Doctrine

“The leadership demonstrated by the United States over these decades in avoiding nuclear war, slowing nuclear proliferation, and shaping an international order that provided decades of great-power peace will go down in history as one of America’s most significant achievements.

Today, as the world confronts the unique challenges posed by another unprecedented and in some ways even more terrifying technology—artificial intelligence—it is not surprising that many have been looking to history for instruction.”

- Henry Kissinger and Graham Allison⁷

Diplomacy is another method of achieving the Trump Doctrine. As much as the Cold War was shaped by nuclear weapons and nuclear non-proliferation, the era of AI will be shaped by AI non-proliferation.

The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons slowed down the spread of nuclear weapons. America’s promise to be a nuclear umbrella, to shield non-nuclear allies, has also contributed to non-proliferation. If America commits to sharing the benefits of AI to non-AI states, this “AI umbrella” could lead to an AI non-proliferation treaty.

While China is a potential adversary, it is still worthwhile to pursue treaties and agreements, but only if compliance can be verified. One recent example is the agreement not to allow nuclear arsenals to be controlled by AI.⁸

⁷ Henry A. Kissinger and Graham Allison, “The Path to AI Arms Control,” *Foreign Affairs*, October 13, 2023, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/henry-kissinger-path-artificial-intelligence-arms-control#>.

⁸ Jarrett Renshaw and Trevor Hunnicutt, “Biden, Xi Agree That Humans, Not AI, Should Control Nuclear Arms,” *Reuters*, November 17, 2024, sec. World, <https://www.reuters.com/world/biden-xi-agreed-that-humans-not-ai-should-control-nuclear-weapons-white-house-2024-11-16/>.

Industry and the Trump Doctrine

The national interest, to protect and defend the United States of America, and the interests of AI and tech companies, to become the largest and most profitable companies in the world, are not always aligned. AI companies may express opposition to the Trump Doctrine since it prevents them from developing and selling AI products and services to foreign nations. The stereotype of the arms dealer who cynically encourages a war in order to sell to both sides has a parallel in the AI company that promotes an AI arms race between nations so they can sell to all sides.

President Eisenhower once warned that “we must guard against the acquisition of unwarranted influence, whether sought or unsought, by the military-industrial complex.”⁹ The Trump administration should similarly guard against the acquisition of unwarranted influence by a technology industry that will be tempted to put their own interests above the national interest.

Humankind and the Trump Doctrine

“Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority alongside other societal-scale risks such as pandemics and nuclear war.”

- Statement on AI Risk¹⁰

“Only a 20% chance of annihilation.”

- Elon Musk¹¹

The Trump Doctrine is aligned with the interests of AI safety and security researchers. Researchers fear that an AI race, between companies or between countries, will lead to corner-cutting and unsafe AI practices, putting humankind itself at risk. By reducing the number of developers, the Trump Doctrine makes it easier and more likely that the developers will coordinate to reduce these profound risks.

⁹ Dwight Eisenhower, “President Dwight D. Eisenhower’s Farewell Address (1961),” National Archives, September 29, 2021, <https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/president-dwight-d-eisenhowers-farewell-address>.

¹⁰ Center for AI Safety, “Statement on AI Risk,” 2023, <https://www.safe.ai/work/statement-on-ai-risk>.

¹¹ Ana Altchek, “Elon Musk Says There’s ‘only a 20% Chance of Annihilation’ with AI,” Business Insider, March 1, 2025, <https://www.businessinsider.com/elon-musk-only-chance-of-annihilation-with-ai-2025-2>.

Further measures to reduce risk include creating an “AI football”, similar to the nuclear football that accompanies the President at all times. If the worst case scenario does happen, the President should have the option of taking down AI systems when the necessity arises.¹²

¹² vitruvian potato [@vitrupe], “PJ Maykish: AGI Arrives next Presidency. We Know How to Break AI Systems, but No Framework to Stop Rogue AGI or Autonomous Cyberattacks. Will the President Get a Kill Switch? <https://t.co/oSXnP6Wp8Q>,” Tweet, *Twitter*, January 13, 2025, <https://x.com/vitrupe/status/1878606726343413887>.

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<https://www.reuters.com/world/biden-xi-agreed-that-humans-not-ai-should-control-nuclear-weapons-white-house-2024-11-16/>.
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